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State Route 14 road project back on track

WASHINGTONVILLE

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WASHINGTONVILLE— The proposed road project at state Route 14 and Washingtonville Road is back on track. Representatives from the Ohio Department of Transportation (ODOT) visited the regular Village Council meeting Monday night to update the council on the project that will align Washingtonville Road with East Street, provide turning lanes on state Route 14 and install a traffic signal at the intersection. Most notably, the project now calls for 8-foot sidewalks north on both sides of Washingtonville Road and minimal work south on East Street, eliminating any inclusion of the Greenway bike trail on the part of ODOT. The project was set to move forward in December, with no work scheduled on East Street, but council requested the bike trail be incorporated with the street at the urging of several stakeholders, including the Mill Creek MetroParks, the Great Ohio Lake-to-River Greenway and the Eastgate Regional Council of Governments (transportation planning agency for Mahoning and Trumbull counties). Greg Gurney, planning and programs administrator for ODOT District 11, said he attempted to include the trail, but was informed by ODOT's central office that land could not be appropriated for either a bike trail or lane. A later ruling showed that a lane could be incorporated, but the metroparks elected to go with the abnormally wide sidewalks (typical sidewalks are 5 feet wide) due to safety concerns, according to Gurney. ODOT will now complete the environmental stage of the project before developing a construction plan, Gurney said, adding that another public hearing, probably in June, must be held before the project can be approved and started. Councilwoman Renee Jackson voiced concern that the project may have fallen to the side. But Gurney assured her that the money is earmarked specifically for the project, and Eastgate has committed funding, as well, so the only issue regarding the actual renovation of the intersection is when it will be scheduled.

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